stronger fashion than in the West, where another type of fundamentalism seems to reign – the postmodern, a universalist form of an aggressive secular liberalism.

For all these reasons, populism and backsliding of the rule of law in Central Europe should all give us pause for thought – and should also trouble those in the West, equally plagued by different types of populism, xenophobia and even perhaps of trends that could result in the return of Fascism, as Rob Riemen warns us. Recipes on how to fight back should be specific and should not be seen as ideologically driven by post-modern 'woke', which many see as a contemporary version of the Communist threat of pre-war Europe: there are many Christians and other conservatives out there that are scared at the prospect of a new woke totalitarianism that will restrict religious freedom, impinge on the concept of objection of conscience and effectively push them out of the public sphere, making them a second class citizen. But true liberal democracy should not, in principle, have a problem with (socially) conservative policies or religion, Christianity included. Moreover, secularism that does not recognise the potential of religion for social dialogue (and also for the integration of immigrants) will not help. By the same token, social conservatism that does not reject classic liberal freedoms and the European Humanist tradition should be respected, otherwise the defenders of liberal democracy and the rule of law risk alienating important sections of population, East and West. In fact, we need – as Halík has stressed – a coalition of liberals and conservatives, left and right, forging an agreement on an inclusive set of European values that would – while respecting the secular and diverse character of European society today – give recognition to the Christian and Humanist traditions as central pillars of European identity. At the same time, without looking deeper at the roots of left or right populism and other challenges to the rule of law – while not giving in to autocrats – there is a risk of creating new divisions, helping replicate conditions that Europe faced in the 1930s, and deepening the gap between the two halves of Europe at this critical time in its history.

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104. Rachman, G, *The Age of the Strongman*, Bodley Head, London, p. 32.
105. https://www.atlasofeuropeanvalues.eu/
106. Krastev, I, Holmes, S, *The Light that Failed*, Allen Lane, 2019, p. 52.